helped to develop the political prowess of all sides; they learned to work together even when their long-term interests diverged. The government allowed ethnic armed groups to manage designated "special regions" which offered a chance to imagine autonomous cultural and economic policies. Under these often-temperamental conditions, the negotiation of ceasefires was an ongoing process, vulnerable to the whims of new leaders and their commercial associates. In some localities, day-to-day skirmishes have been the pattern for as long as anyone can remember.

The most significant new war of recent years was in northernmost Myanmar, where the old antagonisms between the KIA and the central government reignited. This war, which started in its modern form in 1961, paused under the ceasefire from 1993 to 2011 (for a fuller history see Sadan 2013). Those years of ceasefire created new wealth, in particular among those who controlled the region's extractive industries. Jade, gold and timber offered untold profits for the businesses that exported to China's hungry markets. The ceasefire was made possible by the enmeshment of commercial, political and cultural interests. But nobody was greatly surprised when the ceasefire ended. Years of negotiation about the future of the KIA, and its potential transformation into a so-called Border Guard Force, had left all sides questioning the sincerity of their opponents. When in June 2011 the KIA challenged Myanmar government troops, the escalation came quickly. Within weeks, a tempo of guerrilla ambushes, infantry surges, and hit-and-run attacks had forced 10,000s of people to flee their homes. Soon, more than 100,000 internally displaced people sought refuge from the violence, many huddled against the Chinese border (Cook 2014).

This explosion of conflict generated considerable doubt about the overall trajectory of Myanmar's political changes. It showed that the armed forces remained willing to strike against perceived enemies, including with air power and heavy artillery. Questions about the military's chain of command fueled suspicion about the extent to which it had surrendered power at all. Under the 2008 Constitution, defence, security and border issues remained the preserve of the armed forces, with the commander-in-chief, by this stage Min Aung Hlaing, empowered to appoint uniformed officers to the relevant ministerial posts. In day-to-day operational matters, it was still the regional commands and the Bureau of Special Operations that played the central roles. For Northern Myanmar, it was Bureau of Special Operations No. 1. Its most important subordinate command, Northern Command, is headquartered at Myitkyina, the bustling riverside capital of Kachin State.